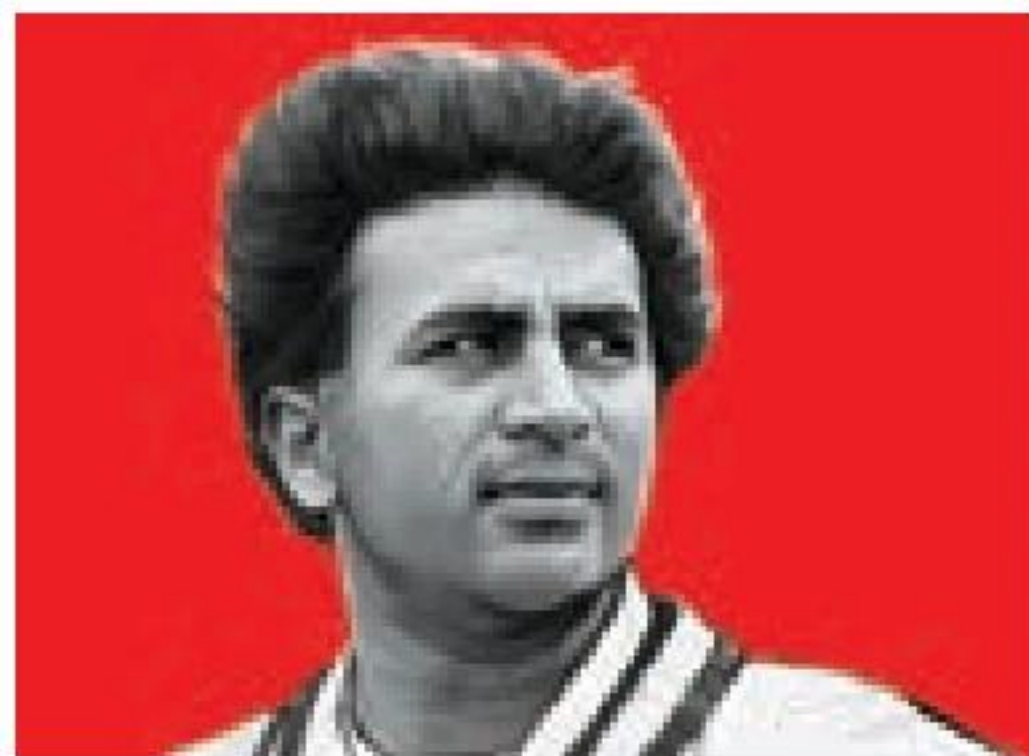




ON THE WRITE LINE

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DOMESTIC CRICKETERS DESERVE MORE THAN APPLAUSE AND SPARSE CROWDS

It is disappointing to see that those who give everything to compete in the National Championships, across different weather conditions, do not even earn the **base price** of an IPL player.

The Mumbai Cricket Association's (MCA) announcement that they will now contract their players, as the Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI) does, is excellent news. This is yet another example of an administration that is alert and alive to the needs of its players, giving them the security to play the game without worrying about where the next pay cheque is coming from.

A couple of years ago, after Mumbai won the Ranji Trophy, the Association not only matched the prize money that the winners receive from the BCCI but also announced that it would pay players what the BCCI pays. This latter part is very important, as players now receive payment from the MCA immediately after a match finishes. BCCI payments do take a little time, as there are payments to be made not just to one team but to several, and determining what each player should receive involves some delay, given the slabs based on the number of matches played. By paying players immediately after the game is over, the

wait for BCCI payments becomes a little easier. Who does not like to be paid immediately after the work is complete?

Today, corporate jobs for players to participate in inter-company tournaments are drying up, so this immediate payment is a boon. **It is understood that two other progressive-minded associations, the Tamil Nadu Cricket Association and the Karnataka State Cricket Association, also pay players for every game, apart from BCCI payments.** Other associations, which receive a handsome subsidy each year from the BCCI, would do well to match these payments. What is the point of showing crores in the bank when players could perform with far greater freedom if they were better looked after?

That said, even players from teams that reach the Ranji Trophy final do not end up earning the base price of Rs. 30 lakh that an IPL player receives. This, mind you, is for playing around 40 days of cricket, while an IPL player earns the same for 16 matches, out of which he may not even play one.